

AP U.S. HISTORY (APUSH) · THE UNIVERSAL STUDY GUIDE

Targeting a 3, 4, or 5 — every concept tagged for your tier

Tier badges: [3] foundational · [4] adds for 4+ · [5] adds for 5

Targeting a 4 → study [3] AND [4] items. Targeting a 5 → study all three tiers.

PAGE 1 | MATH OF 3/4/5 · 9 PERIODS · 7 THEMES (NAT-WXT-GEO-MIG-PCE-WOR-ARC)

About this exam. APUSH covers ~1491 to the present, organized into 9 PERIODS. Same exam structure as AP World/Euro: 55 MCQ + 3 SAQ + 1 DBQ + 1 LEQ. **The biggest difference vs. AP World:** APUSH essays reward thematic argument across periods MORE than chronological narration. Tag every claim with one of the 7 themes.

THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET

Target	MCQ (55q, 40%)	SAQ (3q, 20%)	DBQ (1q, 25%)	LEQ (1q, 15%)	Tier
3 (PASS)	~28-32	~5-6/9	~3-4/7	~2-3/6	[3]
4	~36-40	~7/9	~4-5/7	~3-4/6	[3] + [4]
5	~44-48	~8-9/9	~6-7/7	~5-6/6	All

Time: 55 MCQ in 55 min, 3 SAQ in 40 min, 1 DBQ in 60 min (15 min reading), 1 LEQ in 40 min. **DBQ + LEQ = 40% of score** — efficient writing matters more than length.

THE 9 PERIODS — by exam weight

#	Years	Period name	Weight
1	1491–1607	Encounters: Native Americans, Europeans, West Africans	4–6%
2	1607–1754	Colonial America: 13 colonies + slavery	6–8%
3	1754–1800	Revolution + early republic (heaviest early period)	10–17%
4	1800–1848	Antebellum: market revolution, expansion, reform	10–17%
5	1844–1877	Civil War + Reconstruction (huge weight)	10–17%
6	1865–1898	Gilded Age: industry, Populism, immigration	10–17%
7	1890–1945	Progressive Era → WWI → 1920s → GD → WWII	10–17%
8	1945–1980	Cold War + Civil Rights (heaviest modern period)	10–17%
9	1980–present	Reagan → globalization → contemporary	4–6%

KEY INSIGHT [4] DBQs/LEQs almost ALWAYS come from periods 3-8 (the 10-17% periods). Periods 1, 2, and 9 are MCQ/SAQ territory. Spend study time accordingly.

THE 7 THEMES — "NAT-WXT-GEO-MIG-PCE-WOR-ARC" [3]/[4]

Theme	What it captures
NAT — National Identity	What it means to be American — citizenship, federalism, ideals (liberty, equality, democracy)
WXT — Work, Exchange, Tech	Economic systems, labor, business, capitalism, technology
GEO — Geography & Environment	Land, climate, resources, environmental change, settlement patterns
MIG — Migration & Settlement	Immigration, internal migration, demographic change, urbanization
PCE — Politics & Power	Government, parties, voting, federal vs state, executive/legislative tensions
WOR — America in the World	Foreign policy, wars, diplomacy, US role globally
ARC — American & Regional Culture	Religion, art, literature, popular culture, intellectual movements

[5] On every FRQ, name the theme(s) you're using. "This represents a NAT shift driven by WXT forces (industrialization)..." Naming themes earns context credit + structures your essay.

PAGE 2 | PERIODS 1-2: ENCOUNTERS · COLONIAL AMERICA (1491-1754)

Period 1: Native Americans, Europeans, West Africans (1491–1607) [3]

- **Native societies [3]** were diverse: Pueblos (Southwest), Iroquois (Northeast), Mississippians (mound-builders), Plains. Different agriculture/political structures.
- **Columbian Exchange [3]/[4]** = transfer of plants (corn, potatoes, tobacco, sugar), animals (horses), diseases (smallpox — 90% Native mortality), people (Africans → New World) between Old + New Worlds.
- **Encomienda system [3]/[4]** = Spanish forced labor of Natives. Brutal. Bartolomé de las Casas opposed.
- **Spanish colonial society [4]**: hierarchical (peninsulares > criollos > mestizos > Natives + Africans). Catholic missions.

Period 2: Colonial America (1607–1754) [3]/[4]

Region	Characteristics
Chesapeake [3]	VA + MD. Tobacco. Indentured servitude → African slavery (post-Bacon's Rebellion 1676). Anglican.
New England [3]	MA + CT + RI + NH. Puritans (Mass Bay), small farms, mixed economy, town meetings, schools. Religious dissent (Anne Hutchinson, Roger Williams).
Middle Colonies [3]	NY, PA, NJ, DE. Diverse (Dutch, German, Quaker, Scots-Irish). "Bread basket." Religious tolerance (PA's Quakers).
Southern Colonies [4]	Carolinas + GA. Rice, indigo. Plantation slavery from start. Slave codes (Stono Rebellion 1739).

- **Mercantilism [3]/[4]** = colonies serve mother country. **Navigation Acts** restricted colonial trade. Salutary neglect through ~1750.
- **First Great Awakening (1730s-40s) [4]** = Whitefield, Edwards. Emotional religious revival. Created intercolonial networks + challenged hierarchy.
- **Bacon's Rebellion (1676) [4]** = Virginia farmers vs Gov. Berkeley over Native policy. Led elite to shift from indentured servants to African slaves (more permanent labor force).

Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade [3]/[4]

- **Middle Passage [3]** = brutal trans-Atlantic crossing. ~12 million Africans enslaved 1500-1800; ~10% North American.
- **Slave codes [4]**: legalized chattel slavery, prohibited literacy, made enslavement hereditary.
- **Resistance [4]/[5]**: Stono Rebellion (1739, SC), running away, work slowdowns, preservation of West African culture (foodways, music, religion blended).

PAGE 3 | PERIOD 3: REVOLUTION + EARLY REPUBLIC (1754-1800)**Causes of the Revolution [3]/[4]**

1754-63	French + Indian War (Seven Years' War) – Britain wins, debt explodes
1763	Proclamation Line – bars settlement west of Appalachians
1764	Sugar Act
1765	Stamp Act
1767	Townshend Acts
1770	Boston Massacre
1773	Tea Act → Boston Tea Party
1774	Coercive (Intolerable) Acts → 1st Continental Congress
1775	Lexington + Concord – "shot heard round the world"
1776	Declaration of Independence (Jefferson)
1781	Yorktown – Cornwallis surrenders
1783	Treaty of Paris – independence + Mississippi as western border

Ideological foundations [3]/[4]

- **Enlightenment [3]:** Locke (natural rights, social contract), Montesquieu (separation of powers).
- **Common Sense (Paine, 1776) [3]/[4]** = best-selling pamphlet pushing independence.
- **Republicanism [4]** = government's legitimacy from citizen virtue + consent. Suspicion of standing armies + concentrated power.

Articles of Confederation (1781-89) [3]/[4]

- **Strengths [3]:** won the war, passed Land Ordinance (1785) + Northwest Ordinance (1787 — banned slavery in NW Territory).
- **Weaknesses [3]/[4]:** no taxing power, no executive, no national army, no power to regulate commerce. **Shays' Rebellion (1786-87)** showed weakness → constitutional convention.

Constitution (1787) — compromises [3]/[4]

Great (Connecticut) Compromise:	bicameral legislature
	Senate = 2 per state, House = by population
3/5 Compromise:	slaves count as 3/5 person for representation
Commerce Compromise:	federal can tax imports, NOT exports
Slave Trade Clause:	Congress could ban slave trade after 1808 (did so)
Federalists (Hamilton, Madison, Jay) – Federalist Papers	
Anti-Federalists – demanded Bill of Rights → ratified 1791 (1st 10 amendments)	

Early Republic (Washington, Adams) [3]/[4]

- **Hamilton's economic plan [3]/[4]:** assume state debts, national bank, tariffs, excise tax. **Whiskey Rebellion (1794)** tested federal power.
- **1st 2-party system [4]:** Federalists (Hamilton — strong central gov, pro-British, mercantile) vs Democratic-Republicans (Jefferson — states' rights, pro-French, agrarian).
- **Foreign affairs [4]:** Washington's Farewell Address warned against "entangling alliances". Jay Treaty (1794) appeased Britain. Pinckney Treaty (1795) opened Mississippi.
- **XYZ Affair (1797) + Alien & Sedition Acts (1798) [4]/[5]:** Adams + Federalists overreach → Jefferson wins 1800 ("Revolution of 1800").

KEY INSIGHT [5] On any Period 3 FRQ, connect Constitution debates to LATER consequences. 3/5 compromise → sectional crisis. Federalist/D-R divide → 1st party system → foreign policy splits. Treat ratification as the START of an ongoing political negotiation.

PAGE 4 | PERIODS 4-5: ANTEBELLUM · CIVIL WAR · RECONSTRUCTION (1800-1877)**Period 4: Antebellum (1800–1848) [3]/[4]**

- **Jefferson [3]**: Louisiana Purchase (1803) doubled US. Lewis & Clark. Embargo Act (1807) backfired.
- **War of 1812 [3]/[4]** = US vs Britain. Burning of DC. Battle of New Orleans (Jackson). Treaty of Ghent (1814). Aftermath: nationalism, Federalist death (Hartford Convention).
- **Era of Good Feelings (Monroe, 1817-25) [4]**: one-party. Monroe Doctrine (1823) — no European intervention in Western Hemisphere.
- **Market Revolution [3]/[4]**: canals (Erie 1825), railroads, steamboats, telegraph. Northern factories. Lowell Mills + factory system.
- **Jacksonian Democracy [3]/[4]**: expanded white male suffrage, spoils system, Indian Removal Act (1830) → Trail of Tears, Bank War (vetoed 2nd BUS), nullification crisis (SC 1832).
- **2nd Great Awakening + reform [3]/[4]**: temperance, abolitionism (Garrison's *Liberator*, Frederick Douglass), women's rights (Seneca Falls 1848), education (Horace Mann).

Period 5: Civil War & Reconstruction (1844–1877) [3]/[4]**ROAD TO WAR:**

- 1846-48 Mexican-American War → Mexican Cession
- 1850 Compromise of 1850 (CA free, Fugitive Slave Act)
- 1854 Kansas-Nebraska Act → "Bleeding Kansas"; Republican Party formed
- 1857 Dred Scott v. Sandford — slaves are property, Congress can't ban
- 1859 John Brown's raid on Harpers Ferry
- 1860 Lincoln elected → SC secedes (Dec 1860)
- 1861 Fort Sumter — war begins April 12

WAR (1861-65):

- 1862 Antietam — bloodiest single day → Lincoln issues
- 1863 Emancipation Proclamation (Jan 1) — frees CSA slaves
- Gettysburg + Vicksburg (July) — turning points
- 1865 Appomattox (April 9) — Lee surrenders to Grant
- Lincoln assassinated (April 14)

Reconstruction (1865-77) [3]/[4]/[5]

- **13th, 14th, 15th Amendments [3]**: ban slavery; equal protection + birthright citizenship; voting regardless of race.
- **Presidential vs Radical Reconstruction [4]**: Johnson (lenient toward South) vs Radical Republicans (military districts, Freedmen's Bureau, harsh). Johnson impeached 1868 (acquitted by 1 vote).
- **Black political participation [4]/[5]**: 16 Black congressmen + 2 senators during Reconstruction. Schools, churches established.
- **Backlash [4]/[5]**: KKK terror, Black Codes, sharecropping, redeemer governments.
- **Compromise of 1877 [4]** ended Reconstruction. Federal troops withdrawn. Jim Crow era begins.
- **Plessy v. Ferguson (1896) [4]/[5]** = "separate but equal" — codifies segregation.

KEY INSIGHT [5] Reconstruction = a missed opportunity. Most-tested LEQ angle: the 13/14/15 Amendments transformed citizenship on paper, but Plessy + sharecropping + KKK violence + 1877 withdrawal meant the actual experience of freedom was systematically undermined. This "unfinished revolution" thesis works for any Reconstruction prompt.

PAGE 5 | PERIOD 6: GILDED AGE — INDUSTRY, IMMIGRATION, POPULISM (1865-1898)**Industrial transformation [3]/[4]**

- **Captains of industry / robber barons [3]/[4]:** Carnegie (steel, vertical integration), Rockefeller (oil, horizontal integration via Standard Oil trust), JP Morgan (banking, consolidation).
- **Transcontinental railroad (1869) [3]** = built largely by Chinese + Irish immigrants. Standard time zones. National market.
- **Innovation [4]:** Bessemer steel, electric grid (Edison/Westinghouse), telephone (Bell), assembly-line precursors.
- **Social Darwinism [4]/[5]** (Spencer, Sumner) = misapplied Darwin to society. Used to justify wealth inequality + laissez-faire.
- **Gospel of Wealth (Carnegie) [4]** = wealthy have moral obligation to philanthropy.

Labor [3]/[4]

1869 Knights of Labor – open to all (women, Black, unskilled). Peaked late 1880s.
 1877 Great Railroad Strike – federal troops break it
 1886 Haymarket Affair (Chicago) – bombing → public turns against unions
 1886 AFL formed (Samuel Gompers) – skilled workers only, narrower goals
 1892 Homestead Strike (Carnegie's steel plant) – Pinkertons crush union
 1894 Pullman Strike – Cleveland sends federal troops, ARU (Debs) crushed

Pattern: government + courts SIDE WITH OWNERS. Labor's gains were minimal.

Immigration & Cities [3]/[4]

- **"Old" immigrants [3]** (pre-1880): Irish, German, British, Scandinavian — N/W Europe.
- **"New" immigrants (1880-1924) [3]/[4]:** Italians, Poles, Russians, Jews, Slavs — S/E Europe. Catholic + Jewish, settled in cities, faced discrimination (nativism).
- **Chinese Exclusion Act (1882) [4]** = first major federal immigration restriction by ethnicity.
- **Urbanization [3]:** tenements, settlement houses (Jane Addams' Hull House), political machines (Tammany Hall, Boss Tweed).

Westward expansion + Native Americans [3]/[4]/[5]

- **Homestead Act (1862) [3]/[4]** = 160 acres free to settlers. Drove Plains settlement.
- **Wars + reservations [4]:** Sand Creek (1864), Wounded Knee (1890 — final massacre).
- **Dawes Act (1887) [4]/[5]** = broke up tribal land into individual plots, aimed at "assimilation." Catastrophic loss of Native land.
- **Frederick Jackson Turner's frontier thesis (1893) [5]** = frontier shaped American character. Hugely influential, also flawed (ignored Natives, Mexicans, women).

Populism [4]/[5]

- **Farmers' Alliance → People's Party (1892) [4]/[5]:** rural backlash against railroads, banks, gold standard. Wanted free silver, graduated income tax, direct election of senators, secret ballot.
- **1896 election [4]/[5]:** William Jennings Bryan ("Cross of Gold" speech) vs William McKinley. McKinley wins → end of Populist Party as major force, but Progressives later adopted many ideas.

PAGE 6 | PERIOD 7 PT 1: PROGRESSIVE ERA · WWI · 1920s (1890-1929)**Progressive Era (~1900-1920) [3]/[4]**

- **Muckrakers [3]/[4]:** Tarbell (Standard Oil), Sinclair (*The Jungle* → Meat Inspection Act 1906), Riis (*How the Other Half Lives*).
- **Theodore Roosevelt (1901-09) [3]/[4]:** trust-busting, Square Deal, conservation (national parks), Pure Food + Drug Act.
- **Wilson (1913-21) [3]/[4]:** Federal Reserve Act, Clayton Antitrust Act, 16th Amendment (income tax), 17th Amendment (direct election of senators).
- **Women's suffrage [3]/[4]:** 19th Amendment (1920) — built on decades of activism (Stanton, Anthony, Pankhurst-style militant tactics from Alice Paul).
- **Prohibition [3]/[4]:** 18th Amendment (1919) — banned alcohol. Led to bootlegging, speakeasies, organized crime. Repealed 1933 (21st).

Imperialism + WWI [3]/[4]

- **Spanish-American War (1898) [3]:** "splendid little war." US gained Philippines, Puerto Rico, Guam. Annexed Hawaii (1898).
- **Roosevelt Corollary (1904) [4] =** US would intervene in Latin America to maintain stability. "Big stick" diplomacy.
- **Panama Canal (1914) [4] =** US engineering project. Bypassed Colombia by backing Panamanian independence.
- **WWI entry (1917) [3]/[4]:** Lusitania (1915), Zimmermann telegram (1917), unrestricted submarine warfare. Wilson's "war to end all wars" + 14 Points.
- **Home front [4]:** War Industries Board, Espionage + Sedition Acts, Committee on Public Information. Great Migration of Black Americans to North.
- **Treaty of Versailles + League of Nations [3]/[4] =** Senate REJECTS (Lodge + isolationists). US returns to isolation.

1920s [3]/[4]

- **Republican "return to normalcy" [3] (Harding, Coolidge, Hoover) —** pro-business, low taxes, high tariffs.
- **Roaring Twenties [3]/[4]:** assembly-line consumption (Ford Model T), credit, advertising, radio, movies. Flappers + changing gender norms.
- **Harlem Renaissance [3]/[4]:** Hughes, Hurston, Ellington, Armstrong. Black cultural flourishing in NYC.
- **Tensions [4]/[5]:** KKK revival (anti-Catholic, anti-Jewish, anti-immigrant), Scopes Trial (1925, evolution vs religion), Sacco + Vanzetti (anti-Italian/anarchist), National Origins Act (1924) restricted immigration by quotas.

KEY INSIGHT [5] The 1920s were not just "prosperity." They were a contested cultural moment: urban vs rural, modern vs traditional, immigrant vs nativist. Use this tension on any 1920s FRQ — the prosperity narrative ignores Black migration to Harlem, KKK terror, immigration restriction, etc.

PAGE 7 | PERIOD 7-8: GREAT DEPRESSION · WWII · COLD WAR (1929-1980)**Great Depression + New Deal [3]/[4]**

- **Crash of 1929 [3]** + Hoover's failed response (Smoot-Hawley Tariff worsened it).
- **FDR's New Deal (1933+)** [3]/[4]: 3 R's = Relief, Recovery, Reform.

ALPHABET AGENCIES (most tested):

AAA – Agricultural Adjustment Act (paid farmers to NOT plant)
 CCC – Civilian Conservation Corps (jobs in conservation)
 WPA – Works Progress Administration (large-scale jobs)
 SEC – Securities + Exchange Commission (regulate Wall Street)
 FDIC – Federal Deposit Insurance (banking)
 SSA – Social Security Act (1935) → still here
 NLRA – Wagner Act (1935) → labor unions' right to bargain
 TVA – Tennessee Valley Authority (regional development)

- **Critics [4]**: Huey Long (Share Our Wealth), Father Coughlin, Frances Townsend. Pushed FDR LEFT into 2nd New Deal.
- **Court-packing (1937)** [4]/[5] = FDR's failed attempt to add Supreme Court justices. Damaged his political capital.

WWII (1941-45) [3]/[4]

- **Pearl Harbor (Dec 7, 1941)** [3] brings US in. "Date which will live in infamy."
- **Home front [3]/[4]**: rationing, war bonds, women into factories (Rosie the Riveter), Black migration North + West.
- **Japanese internment [3]/[4]**: 120,000 forced into camps (Korematsu v. US, 1944, upheld it — later condemned). Civil liberties low point.
- **Major operations [3]/[4]**: Midway (1942 turning point Pacific), D-Day (1944), Iwo Jima + Okinawa, atomic bombs (Hiroshima + Nagasaki, Aug 1945).
- **Holocaust [3]/[4]**: 6 million Jews murdered. US response: late, limited refugee admission. Postwar Nuremberg trials.

Cold War origins [3]/[4]

1945 Yalta + Potsdam – Big Three carved up Europe
 1947 Truman Doctrine (contain communism – Greece, Turkey)
 Marshall Plan (rebuild Europe, bind to US)
 1948 Berlin Airlift
 1949 NATO; Mao wins China; USSR detonates atomic bomb
 1950 NSC-68 (massive military buildup)
 1950-53 Korean War – first Cold War hot conflict, ended at 38th parallel

McCarthyism + Civil Rights early [3]/[4]

- **Red Scare [3]/[4]**: HUAC, Hollywood blacklist, Hiss + Rosenbergs. McCarthy's televised hearings (1954) → Senate censure.
- **Brown v. Board (1954)** [3]/[4] = overturned Plessy. "Separate but equal" inherently unequal. Massive resistance in South.
- **Montgomery Bus Boycott (1955-56)** [3]/[4] = Rosa Parks → MLK rises. Year-long boycott.

1960s — JFK/LBJ + Civil Rights peak [3]/[4]

- **JFK (1961-63)** [3]/[4]: Bay of Pigs, Cuban Missile Crisis (1962), space race, assassinated Nov 22, 1963.
- **LBJ's Great Society [3]/[4]**: Civil Rights Act (1964), Voting Rights Act (1965), Medicare/Medicaid, immigration reform.
- **Vietnam (1964-73)** [3]/[4]: Gulf of Tonkin → escalation. Tet (1968) shifted public opinion. Nixon's Vietnamization. Fall of Saigon (1975).
- **Counterculture [4]**: anti-war, hippies, women's lib (NOW), gay rights (Stonewall 1969), environmental movement (Earth Day 1970), Chicano/Latino activism, AIM (Native American).

PAGE 8 | PERIODS 8-9: WATERGATE · REAGAN · CONTEMPORARY (1968-PRESENT)**Late 60s-70s — Crisis decade [3]/[4]**

- **Nixon (1969-74) [3]/[4]**: opened China (1972), détente w/ USSR, EPA, ended draft. **Watergate (1972-74)** → resignation Aug 1974.
- **Stagflation [4]/[5]** = simultaneous inflation + unemployment. OPEC oil embargo (1973) tripled prices. Keynesian model in crisis.
- **Roe v. Wade (1973) [4]** = abortion right (overturned 2022).
- **Carter (1977-81) [4]**: human rights diplomacy, Camp David Accords (1978), but Iran hostage crisis (1979-81) crippled him.

Reagan Revolution + 1980s [3]/[4]

- **Reaganomics [3]/[4]** = supply-side: tax cuts, deregulation, military buildup. Increased deficit + inequality but also growth.
- **Cold War end [3]/[4]**: Reagan's "evil empire" + Strategic Defense Initiative + Gorbachev's reforms → Berlin Wall falls 1989, USSR dissolves 1991.
- **Conservative resurgence [4]/[5]**: Religious Right (Falwell's Moral Majority), Reagan Democrats, evangelicals into politics. Affirmative action backlash.

Post-Cold War (1990s-present) [3]/[4]/[5]

- **Clinton (1993-2001) [3]**: NAFTA, welfare reform, balanced budget, impeached over Lewinsky.
- **Gulf War (1991) [4]** = Bush Sr. coalition expels Iraq from Kuwait. Quick victory.
- **9/11 (2001) + War on Terror [3]/[4]**: Afghanistan (2001+), Iraq (2003-11), Patriot Act, Guantanamo, drone wars.
- **Obama (2009-17) [3]/[4]**: ACA (2010), Dodd-Frank, Iran deal, marriage equality (Obergefell 2015), DACA.
- **Trends [4]/[5]**: globalization, deindustrialization (Rust Belt), tech boom, climate awareness, immigration debates, BLM/George Floyd, COVID-19.

KEY INSIGHT [5] On Period 9 (post-1980) FRQs, anchor your answer in continuities from earlier periods. Reagan conservatism = response to 60s liberalism. Globalization = next phase of post-WWII US economic dominance. Tea Party + Trump = continuity of populist anti-elite movements (Andrew Jackson, Bryan, Long, Wallace). The 5 thesis connects across periods.

PAGE 9 | FRQ DECODER — SAQ · DBQ · LEQ

THE 4 FRQ TYPES — points + structure [3]/[4]

Type	Points	Quick recipe
SAQ (3q × 3 pt)	9	No thesis needed. A/B/C: each part = 1 sentence claim + 1 specific evidence + 1 sentence elaboration. Tight, factual.
DBQ (1 q)	7	Thesis (1) + Context (1) + Evidence: 4 docs (1) → 6 docs supporting argument (3) + 1 outside evidence (1) + Sourcing/HIPP for 2 docs (1) + Complex understanding (1).
LEQ (1 q, choice of 3)	6	Thesis (1) + Context (1) + 2 specific evidence (1) → use it for argument (1) + Reasoning structure (1) + Complex understanding (1).

The DBQ — 7 points decoded [3]/[4]/[5]

- **Thesis [3]** = defensible claim, NOT just restatement. Place at end of intro OR conclusion.
- **Contextualization [3]** = 2-3 sentences setting up the broader era BEFORE/around the prompt window. Don't just restate the prompt.
- **Document use [3]/[4]**: USE 4 docs minimally → use 6 to SUPPORT thesis (not just describe). Quote/paraphrase + name the doc.
- **Outside evidence [3]/[4]** = something specific NOT in any document. One named person, event, law.
- **Sourcing (HIPP) [4]** = for ≥2 docs, explain HOW one of: Historical situation, Intended audience, Point of view, Purpose affects what the document says.
- **Complex understanding [5]** = nuance, multiple causes, counter-evidence, modification of thesis. Hardest point.

The LEQ — choice of 3 prompts [4]/[5]

LEQ gives 3 prompt options spanning different periods (e.g., one each from periods 3-5, 5-7, 7-9). **Pick the one with the strongest specific evidence in your memory** — not the one that sounds easiest abstractly.

- **[4] LEQ thesis** = same defensible claim format as DBQ. Compare/contrast or cause/effect or change/continuity prompts.
- **[5] Complex understanding LEQ tactics**: trace continuity AND change; analyze multiple causes; address counter-claim explicitly.

DBQ Document Sourcing — HIPP examples [4]/[5]

EXAMPLE: Document is a 1893 Frederick Jackson Turner essay.

H – Historical situation:

"Written just after the 1890 Census declared the frontier closed,"
"and during economic depression – Turner's anxiety reflects the era."

I – Intended audience:

"Academic historians at the World's Fair – Turner shaped how a generation"
"of historians interpreted the American character."

P – Point of view:

"Turner, a Wisconsin academic, romanticized the frontier and ignored"
"Native Americans, Mexicans, and women – limiting his thesis's accuracy."

P – Purpose:

"Turner aimed to define a uniquely American identity at a moment of"
"national anxiety, justifying continued expansion."

KEY INSIGHT [4] Pick ONE of HIPP per document, not all 4. Make it explicit: "Because the author was [P]..." or "Given the [H]...". Two sourced documents = the sourcing point.

PAGE 10 | SCORE LADDER · TIER CHECKLISTS · THE ONE THING

THE SCORE LADDER

For a 3 (Pass)	For a 4	For a 5
MCQ: 28-32 / 55	MCQ: 36-40 / 55	MCQ: 44-48 / 55
SAQ: 5-6/9 (one solid sentence per part)	SAQ: 7/9 (specific evidence each part)	SAQ: 8-9/9 (every part nailed)
DBQ: thesis + 4 docs + simple context.	DBQ: thesis + 6 docs + 1 outside ev. + 2 sourcing.	DBQ: all 7 incl. complex understanding.
LEQ: thesis + 2 evidence + simple structure.	LEQ: thesis + reasoning + multiple specifics.	LEQ: complex understanding (counter-claim, nuance).
Know 9 period overviews + key dates.	Add: 7 themes + sourcing (HIPP) + change-over-time.	Add: continuity-vs-change threads + historiographical nuance.

TIER-SPECIFIC TEST-DAY CHECKLISTS

For a 3 — focus only on these:

- ✓ MCQ: 28+ correct.
- ✓ SAQ: 1 sentence claim + 1 specific fact + 1 elaboration per part — every time.
- ✓ Know the 9 period names + key turning points.
- ✓ DBQ: at least thesis + use 4 docs + simple context.
- ✓ Write in past tense.

For a 4 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 36+ correct.
- ✓ DBQ uses 6+ docs to ARGUE (not just describe), with 1 outside evidence + 2 HIPP sourcing.
- ✓ Tag every claim with one of NAT-WXT-GEO-MIG-PCE-WOR-ARC.
- ✓ Name turning points by date (1763, 1776, 1787, 1865, 1898, 1929, 1945, 1989).

For a 5 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 44+ correct.
- ✓ Complex understanding on DBQ + LEQ (counter-claim, multiple causes, nuance, qualification).
- ✓ Discuss continuities AND changes across periods.
- ✓ Use "Reconstruction = unfinished revolution" or similar period-spanning thesis when relevant.
- ✓ Acknowledge competing historical interpretations.

THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST [3][4][5]: ARGUE WITH SPECIFIC NAMED EVIDENCE. APUSH rewards specificity — names, dates, laws, court cases, treaties. "The government took action" earns 0. "Through the Wagner Act of 1935, FDR's Second New Deal protected workers' right to organize, building on labor activism since the Knights of Labor in the 1880s" earns full credit. Always: NAME a person, place, date, law, OR case. Vague generalities lose; specific names + dates + laws win.

If you do nothing else: master the 9 periods + 7 themes, drill the DBQ rubric, and load every essay with named specifics. That's the APUSH formula.

DISCLOSURE & TERMS OF USE

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